

CHEST & ARMS HYPERTROPHY PROGRAM (v5.1)

Barbell Bench Edition & Anatomical Guide | Swimmer Program (Age 56)

FASTED SWIM

2,300m (7:00 AM)

GYM FREQUENCY

2 Days / Week

PRIMARY LIFTS

Incline & Flat BB Press

JOINT SAFETY

Rotator Cuff Focus

FASTED SWIM & GYM TIMING PROTOCOL

TIME WINDOW	ACTIVITY / EVENT	NUTRITIONAL & RECOVERY STRATEGY
06:45 AM	Pre-Swim Prep	Hydrate with 500ml water + electrolytes. Swim is kept 100% fasted.
07:00–08:00 AM	2,300m Swim Session	Maintain steady cadence. 1,500m Freestyle pulls heavy on internal rotators; 800m Backstroke counters chest tightness.
08:30 AM	Post-Swim Break-Fast	35g–40g Protein + Complex Carbs (e.g., 4 eggs + oatmeal or whey smoothie). Stops muscle breakdown post-swim.
OPTION A: 04:30 PM (Recommended)	Gym Workout (2x/Wk) e.g., Tue & Fri	Allows 8+ hours between swim and gym. Pre-workout snack 45 mins prior. Maximizes barbell pressing strength and CNS recovery.
OPTION B: 09:15 AM (Back-to-Back)	Gym Workout (2x/Wk) Immediate post-swim	Consume a quick protein shake + fast carbs immediately after swim before starting gym warm-up.

WARM-UP & COOL-DOWN PROTOCOLS

Warm-Up Protocol (5–8 mins) — Rowing Machine Ergometer

Execution: Smooth 20–22 stroke/min pace. Lubricates shoulder joints and activates upper back (rhomboids & rear delts) to prepare for heavy barbell bench pressing. Follow with dynamic band pull-aparts and arm circles.

Cool-Down & Spinal Decompression — Passive Bar Dead Hangs

- Timing:** The end of your session (ideal).
- Why:** Heavy pressing and rowing compress your spine and tighten your upper back and shoulders. Ending your workout with a dead hang reverses that compression, relaxes tight muscles, and resets your posture before you walk out the door.
- How to do it:** 2 to 3 sets of 30 to 60 seconds as part of your cool-down. Keep it passive — just relax and let gravity pull your hips down.

RULES OF HYPERTROPHY & JOINT SAFETY (AGE 56)

Rule 1: The 3-Second Eccentric Rule (Controlled Barbell Lowering)

At age 56, lowering heavy barbell weight uncontrollably increases shoulder and elbow tendon wear without extra muscle gain. Lower every bench press and curl over 3 slow seconds to maximize mechanical muscle tension while keeping joints completely safe.

Rule 2: Barbell Pressing Path & Scapular Retraction

Never press with flared elbows (90°). On both the Flat and Incline Barbell Bench Press, tuck your elbows to a 45°–60° angle to your torso and keep your shoulder blades pinched tightly together into the bench. This isolates the pecs and protects your rotator cuffs from swimmer's impingement.

Rule 3: Keep 1 to 2 Reps in Reserve (RPE 8 Training Threshold)

Do not train to absolute muscle failure on barbell presses. End your set when you could complete 1 or 2 more clean reps with proper form. This preserves central nervous system recovery for your 7:00 AM daily swims.

Rule 4: Posterior Shoulder Counter-Balance

Freestyle swimming and barbell chest pressing both tighten internal rotators (pectoralis major & lats). Never skip your Rear Delt Flyes or Seated Rows—they pull your shoulder heads back into optimal joint alignment.

WORKOUT A: UPPER CHEST BARBELL, MID-BACK & ARM PEAK

A1 Incline Barbell Bench Press		KEY COMPOUND	3 Sets × 6–8 Reps
Target: Upper Chest / Clavicular Pecs & Front Delts		Tempo: 3s Lower 1s Touch 1s Press	
- Set bench angle strictly to 30 degrees (minimizes front shoulder strain). - Tuck elbows at 45° to 60° to body; do not flare out to 90°. - Touch bar to upper collarbone/sternum area without bouncing off chest.			
A2 Seated Cable Row (Neutral Grip)		3 Sets × 10–12 Reps	
Target: Rhomboids & Mid-Traps		Tempo: 1s Pull 2s Squeeze 2s Return	
- Crucial shoulder counter-balance for freestyle swim pulls. - Pull handle to belly button while driving shoulder blades together.			
A3 Flat Machine Chest Press		3 Sets × 10–12 Reps	
Target: Main Chest / Sternal Pecs		Tempo: 2s Lower 1s Controlled Press	
- Provides safe hyper-isolation volume following heavy barbell benching. - Focus on squeezing inner chest together without locking elbows hard.			
A4 Standing Supinating Dumbbell Curls		3 Sets × 10–12 Reps	
Target: Biceps Brachii (Peak Zone)		Tempo: Smooth Curl 2s Descent	
- Keep elbows stationary at your sides; turn palm outward at peak contraction. - Avoid body swing to keep tension strictly on biceps.			
A5 Cable Rope Tricep Pushdown		3 Sets × 10–12 Reps	
Target: Triceps Lateral / Outer Head		Tempo: Dynamic 1s Split Hold	
Pin elbows tight to torso; pull rope handles apart at bottom lockout.			
A6 Reverse Pec Deck (Rear Delt Fly)		2 Sets × 12–15 Reps	
Target: Rear Deltoids & Rotator Cuff		Benefit: Essential post-swim joint safety	
- Sit facing pad. Drive handles backward using rear shoulders. - Protects shoulders against swimmer's forward posture imbalance.			

WORKOUT B: FLAT BARBELL CHEST MASS, BRACHIALIS & TRICEP LONG HEAD

B1 Flat Barbell Bench Press KEY COMPOUND

3 Sets × 6–8 Reps

Target: Overall Chest / Sternal Pecs, Delts & Triceps

Tempo: 3s Lower | 1s Pause | Explosive Press

- Lock in scapular retraction (pinch shoulder blades down & back into bench).
- Lower bar to mid-lower sternum; press upward in slight arc toward eye level.
- Keep 45° elbow tuck to protect swimmer's rotator cuff joints.

B2 Chest-Supported Machine Row

3 Sets × 10–12 Reps

Target: Upper Back & Rear Shoulders

Benefit: Zero lower back strain; 100% upper back

- Drive elbows outward wide to balance heavy swim pulling forces.
- Keep chest firmly pressed against pad throughout entire set.

B3 Pec Deck Machine Fly

3 Sets × 12–15 Reps

Target: Inner Sternal Chest / Mid Pecs

Tempo: 2s Stretch | 1s Squeeze | 2s Return

- Sit facing away from the machine; adjust seat height so handles align directly with mid-chest.
- Maintain a slight, rigid flex in elbows; drive handles together in front of sternum, squeezing hard for 1 second at peak contraction.
- Provides smooth, continuous mechanical tension across pecs with zero lower back or wrist instability.

B4 Dumbbell Hammer Curls

3 Sets × 10–12 Reps

Target: Brachialis & Forearms

Grip: Neutral thumb-up for arm width

- Pushes biceps upward for thicker overall arm appearance.
- Avoid swinging; lower under complete control (2–3 seconds).

B5 Seated DB Overhead Tricep Extension UPDATED

3 Sets × 10–12 Reps

Target: Triceps Long Head

Benefit: Maximum long-head stretch with zero cable setup

- Sit on a backed bench; cup one dumbbell overhead with both hands, elbows pointing forward.
- Lower behind head until the long head is fully stretched (3 seconds), then press up cleanly.
- Keep upper arms fixed next to ears and ribs down; do not let elbows flare wide.

B6 Reverse Pec Deck (Machine Rear Delt Fly) UPDATED

2 Sets × 12–15 Reps

Target: Posterior Deltoids & Rotator Cuff

Benefit: Maximum stability, zero cable hassle

- Sit facing the chest pad; keep chest against the pad and shoulder blades stable.
- Drive handles backward wide using the rear shoulders to shield rotator cuffs against swim strain.

EQUIPMENT AVAILABILITY & EXERCISE SWAPPING MATRIX

A1 (Incline Barbell Bench Press) and **B1 (Flat Barbell Bench Press)** are your non-negotiable anchor lifts that you should make every effort to do first. Because these use heavy loads in the 6–8 rep range, doing them late in the session after your chest, shoulders, and triceps are already fatigued increases injury risk and degrades your strength gains.

How to prioritize the rest of your exercises when machines are occupied

1. High Priority (Do 1st or 2nd)

- **A1 & B1 (Barbell Benches):** Always try to secure the bench rack first while your central nervous system is fresh.
- **A2 & B2 (Seated / Chest-Supported Rows):** Heavy pulling movements. If the bench is taken when you walk in, do your row first instead of standing around. Swapping A1/B1 with A2/B2 as your starting move is completely fine and actually provides a great shoulder warm-up.

2. Medium Priority (Flexible Middle Moves)

- **A3 (Flat Machine Chest Press) & B3 (Pec Deck Fly):** These are higher-rep (10–15) chest isolation and volume builders. If the equipment is busy, you can safely skip ahead to rear delts or biceps and come back to these without ruining your main strength progression.

3. Fully Swappable (Do Anywhere Near the End)

- **A4 & B4 (Dumbbell Curls / Hammer Curls):** Pure arm isolation. You can do these in any empty space with dumbbells at any point during the second half of your workout.
- **A5 & B5 (Cable Pushdown / Seated DB Overhead Extension):** B5 now needs only a dumbbell and a backed bench, so it never depends on a free cable station. *Golden rule:* never do these before your bench press (A1/B1) or machine press (A3). Pre-exhausting your triceps will cause your chest presses to fail prematurely. As long as your pressing is done, move these anywhere.
- **A6 & B6 (Reverse Pec Deck — both days):** Low-risk, high-rep isolation on the same machine. These can be plugged into almost any open slot late in the workout or saved for the very end; if the pec deck is taken, wait it out or use a bench-supported dumbbell rear delt fly.

THE GOLDEN RULE FOR YOUR SPECIFIC ROUTINE: If a rack for A1/B1 isn't open, jump straight to your row (A2/B2) or your rear delts (A6/B6) to get moving — just hold off on tricep isolation until your main pushing lifts are completed.

MASTER WEEKLY SCHEDULE TEMPLATE

DAY	MORNING (7:00 AM)	AFTERNOON / EVENING	PRIMARY FOCUS
Monday	2,300m Swim (Fasted)	Rest / Light Mobility	Aerobic Recovery & Base Swim
Tuesday	2,300m Swim (Fasted)	GYM: WORKOUT A	Incline Barbell Chest, Mid-Back, Biceps, Outer Tricep
Wednesday	2,300m Swim (Fasted)	Optional Tennis / Run	Cardio & Agility Focus
Thursday	2,300m Swim (Fasted)	Rest / Active Recovery	Aerobic Recovery & Base Swim
Friday	2,300m Swim (Fasted)	GYM: WORKOUT B	Flat Barbell Chest, Upper Back, Brachialis, Tricep Long Head
Saturday	2,300m Swim (Fasted)	Optional Tennis / Run	Cardio & Agility Focus
Sunday	2,300m Swim (Fasted)	Full Rest & Reset	Systemic Recovery & Repair

Summary Strategy: Your 7 AM swim is your untouchable physical & mental foundation. The 2 gym days feature heavy compound barbell pressing for upper body mass paired with strict upper back pulling, posterior shoulder isolation, and passive bar dead hangs to keep your joints healthy for life.